Baby Einstein

By David Sedaris

INTRODUCTION

The birth of a baby brings a family and their issues back together in a way nothing else can. Sedaris presents multiple generations of his family as a powerful force both pulling their children towards the family's collective aspirations and pushing them in the opposite direction. The Sedaris family vies against each other, and the other grandparents, for influence in the life of their youngest sibling's unborn child in David Sedaris's Baby Einstein.

My MOTHER AND I WERE on the beach, rubbing oil into each other's backs and guessing who in the family would be the first to have children. "I think it will be Lisa," I said. This was in the early 1970S. Lisa was maybe fourteen years old and while she wasn't necessarily maternal, she did do things according to their order. Getting married was what came after graduating from college, and having a baby was what came after getting married. "Mark my

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words," I said, "by the age of twenty-six Lisa will have children."

It felt very prophetic, but my mother dismissed it. "No," she said. "Gretchen will be the first." She squinted toward her second daughter, who stood on the shore, pitching meat scraps to a flock of gulls. "It's written on her hips. It will be Gretchen, then Lisa, then Tiffany."

I did not include my brother in the baby prophecy, because every time I saw him he was destroying something, not by accident but willfully, gleefully. He'd dismember his baby, with every intention of putting it back together, but then something would come up - a karate movie, the chance to eat two dozen tacos - and the reconstruction would be forgotten about.

Neither my mother nor I could have imagined that the boy smashing bottles on the path to our cottage would be the first and only one in the family to have a child. By the time it happened, she would be

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long gone and my sisters, my father, and I would have to bear the shock alone. "It happened so fast!" we would say to one another, speaking as if Paul was like us and preceded every action with ten years of discussion. But he's not like us, and to hear him tell it, the debate ended, and shortly after getting married, he called me to announce that Kathy was pregnant.

"Since when?" I asked.

Paul held the phone away from his mouth and yelled into the other room. "Mama, what time is it?"

"You're calling her 'Mama'?"

He yelled for her again, and I told him that if it was four O'clock in Paris, it was ten A.M. in Raleigh. "So how long has she been pregnant?"

He figured it had been about nine hours. And Kathy had become Mama, which would eventually change to Big Mama, and later, for no particular reason, Mama D.

After hanging up, he went to the store and bought a nursing chair, a changing table, and a bib

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reading I LOVE MY DADDY. I thought of those children you sometimes see at demonstrations. ANOTHER TODDLER FOR PEACE, their T-shirts read, or, my favorite, I'M so GLAD MY MOMMY DIDN'T ABORT ME.

"Shouldn't you wait until the baby can talk and say that kind of thing for itself?" I asked. "Or maybe at least hold out until it has a real neck. What are you doing buying bibs?"

The next time he called he was at the counter of a toy store charging a set of *Baby Einstein* videos. "I don't care if it's a boy or a girl, but this little kid is going to have brains."

"Well, it's sure not going to get them from his parents," I said. "Kathy hasn't even gone to the doctor and already you've got videos?"

"crib, too, and I'll tell you what, this stuff is expensive."

"Well, so is calling France on a cell phone at eleven o'clock on a Wednesday morning," I said,

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though again, I don't know who I thought I was talking to. My brother can't survive unless he's breathing into a telephone. If you're an enemy, he'll call only once a day, but if you're a family member and on relatively good speaking terms, you're guaranteed to hear from him once every eight hours or so. There's the money he spends calling us, and then there's the money my sisters and I spend calling one another to talk about how much our brother calls us.

Like everyone else in the family, I kept a list of possible names and called every so often to offer them up: Dusty, Ginger, Kaneesha - all of them rejected. The contractors and carpenters my brother works with suggested names as well, most of them inspired by the pending war or the image of America as a tarnished but still shining beacon. Liberty was popular, as was Glory, the slightly Italian-sounding Vendetta, and Kick Saddam's Butt. Which, as my father pointed out, didn't leave much

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room for a middle name. All of his suggestions were Greek and were offered with a complete disregard of the inevitable taunting they would inspire. "You can't enter the third grade with a name like Hercules," Lisa told him.

Then there was the pressure of naming the child after one of its grandparents. Lou and Sharon were options, but there was also Kathy's family to consider. "Oh, right," my sister Amy said. "Them." The Wilsons were nice people, but we saw them as interlopers, potential threats standing between us and what we'd come to think of as the Sedaris baby. "Don't Kathy's parents already *have* a grandchild?" I asked, speaking as if a grandchild were like a Social Security number or a spinal column - something you needed only one of. We decided they were greedy and capable of anything, yet when the time came to compete, we completely dropped the ball. Their team was out in full force when the baby was born, while we were

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represented by only Lisa and our father. Kathy was in labor for fifteen hours before the doctors decided to perform a cesarean.

They named her Madelyn, which was shortened to Maddy by the time she reached the incubator. I was in a hotel in Portland, Oregon, at the time and received the news from my brother, who called from the recovery room. His voice was soft and melodic, not much more than a whisper. "Mama's got some tubes sticking out of her, but it ain't no big thing," he said. "She's lying back, little Maddy's just as happy as she can be." This was the new, gentler Paul: same vocabulary, but the tone was sweeter and seasoned with a sense of wonder. The cesarean had been unpleasant, but after bemoaning the months wasted in Lamaze class, he grew reflective. "Some is cut loose and others come out on their own self, but take heed, brother: having a baby is a miracle."

"Did you just say, 'Take heed'?" I asked.

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Kathy returned home later that week, but there were problems. Her legs were swollen. She couldn't breathe. An ambulance carried her to the emergency room, where they drained thirty pounds of fluid from her body: Kathy could not have any more children. "Her heart's too weak," Paul said "but can you believe that?" His new voice temporarily disappeared. "Breaking bad on Mama D when she's on tap and already scared half to death?"

His mind was on these things: his sick wife, the baby he was caring for on his own, and the second, hoped-for child he knew now they could never have.

I flew to Raleigh two weeks after the baby was born. Madelyn was asleep when we arrived, and Paul, my father, and I gathered around the crib to adore her in soft voices. One of them suggested that she resembled my mother, but to me she just looked like a baby, not the cute kind you see on

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diaper commercials but the raw, wrinkled kind that resemble bitter old men.

When my father left, Paul heated up a serving of formula. The baby woke up, and Kathy settled her onto the sofa, where the four of us watched videos taken in the hospital. That my brother had not filmed the actual cesarean led me to believe that someone had expressly forbidden it, perhaps for legal or sanitary reasons. There was a blank spot between the arrival of the doctor and the purple-faced baby wailing like an urgent call at the end of her umbilical cord. As if to make up for the missing seven minutes, the recovery-room footage goes on forever. Kathy drinks from a plastic cup of water. A nurse wanders in to change the bandages. Sometimes my sister-in-law held the camera, and we saw Paul in his cutoff shorts and promotional T-shirt, a baseball cap turned backward on his head.

The two of them had watched this video

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dozens of times, but still they sat enraptured. "Here's where that nurse's aide comes in," Kathy said. Paul turned off the volume and as the woman stuck her head through the door he lip-synched her voice.

"Look like evabody in here asleep."

"Do it again," Kathy said.

"Look like evabody in here asleep." "Again."

"Look like evabody in here asleep."

He held Madelyn up to the TV screen and she gave a little, two-syllable cry that sounded to Paul like "whoopee!" but I interpreted as something closer to "help meeeee."

People who have nothing to prove offer practical baby gifts: sturdy cotton rompers made to withstand the cycle of vomit and regular washing. People who are competing for the titles of best-loved aunts and uncles - people like my sisters and me - send satin pants and delicate hand-crafted sweaters accompanied by notes

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reading "P.S. The fur collar is detachable." The baby is photographed in each new outfit, and I receive pictures almost daily. In them my brother and his wife look not like parents but like backwoods kidnappers, secretly guarding the heiress to a substantial cashmere fortune.

Between the still cameras and the video cameras, Madelyn's every move is documented and presented as "Baby's First ... " Baby's First Beach Trip doubled as Baby's First Hurricane. Supported by her mother, she looks past the bent sea oats and out toward the blackening sky, her face creased in an expression of wisdom and concern never seen on either of her parents. The Fourth of July, Halloween, Thanksgiving: these are just days to her, but Paul and Kathy, their logic paralyzed by love, insist that their daughter is cognizant and as excited as they are.

On Baby's First Day of Winter Madelyn sat before a video of *A Christmas Carol*, then watched

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as, in imitation of a Victorian gentleman, my brother applied a pair of muttonchop sideburns. This was accomplished not with a disguise kit, but simply, using two strips of raw bacon that ran along his jawline and remained in place for minutes at a time through the miracle of fat against human flesh. Then Paul got out the ladder and taped Christmas lights to the front of his house. They too were short-term, collapsing into the bushes moments after the picture was taken. The baby, of course, already knew what she would be getting. Gifts were presented the moment my brother returned from the store. Baby's First Pop-Up Book. Baby's First Talking Doll…

My sister-in-law's condition calls for her to sleep through the night, so when Madelyn wakes at two and three and five A.M., it is Paul's job to feed her or change her, or carry her around the house, begging her to lighten up. There's no point in going to bed, so he kicks his pillow from room to

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room and collapses on the floor in front of her crib or the swinging chair that sits in the dining room. When the last of my sisters has hit the sack, he dials me up and holds the receiver to his daughter's mouth. For month I listened to her cry long-distance, but then she got a little older and learned how to laugh and coo and sigh in that satisfied baby way that makes me understand how some could bring a child into this lousy world of ours.

"She'll turn on him sooner or later," my father says. 'Just you wait. In a couple of years Madelyn won't want anything to do with him."

I look into the future and see my brother's face, impossibly middle-aged. His daughter has rejected all of his values, and stands now on the dais of a major university, the valedictorian preparing to deliver her commencement speech. What will she think when her dad stands in the aisle, releasing a hog call and raising his T-shirt to

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reveal the jiggling message painted upon his bare stomach? Will she turn away, as my father predicts, or might she remember all the nights she awoke to discover him: this slob, this lump, this silly drooling toy asleep at her feet.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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